

The Elven Hour

—“Alright, children, today I am going to tell you a story about an elf.”

—“What’s an elf, Varaz?”

DEEP in the forest, in a place even the trees don’t know exactly where it is, there live these wondrous elves. The most beautiful creatures mankind has never seen. 🍄

—“You’re saying it wrong, Varaz!”

—“No, no, Āzar, no human has ever been able to lay eyes on them.”

—“They are invisible?”

NO, not at all. They are just very good at hiding. For humans are not supposed to know that they are around. So that they can carry out their sacred task. 🍄

—“What is that, Varaz?”

—“To protect us.”

—“Huh?”

AND there, in the forest, walks our elven daughter, freshly graduated from elven school, ready to meet her new charge. She is so excited: her first human. And they told her it is going to be a princess. That’s a big honor, even for elves, to be allowed in helping a princess, protecting her from evil and other bad things—like the hiccups, or toothache. And so now, she is on her way to the land of the Gifted. It’s a beautiful land, where the fields are fertile and the meadows are mellow, where the streams gleam and the soil toils. And everything is protected from the cold winds of the east or the storms that blow from the north by high mountains all around. The Gifted people surely have been gifted with this giving land!

And when she steps into the palace, there on his throne, is seated the benevolent and just king Kunimund, protector of his gifted kin. And next to him on the throne sits his noble and graceful queen. And in front of them stands their beautiful daughter, Rose-o-World. Our elven daughter is so excited, is this going to be her new charge? But an older elf

puts his hand on her shoulder and says.

~“Daughter of the forest, not yet. The girl that needs your protection has not arrived yet. Be patient!” No big deal, our elven daughter doesn’t mind waiting. So, she sits down and watches the doings at Kunimund’s court, and sees first-hand, how the king reigns justly and sees to it that every one gets their fair share. And the queen rules generously, and sees to it that every one is well-fed. And peace endures, for the Emperor is pleased with his gifted subjects and allows Kunimund to rule these blessed lands. It’s all just like they taught her at elven school. So, she sits there, waiting patiently. For elves can be very patient. See, one time, at school, her teacher told her

~“Sit here, daughter of the forest, next to this chicken, and watch for it to lay an egg.” So, she sits down and watches the chicken. But the bird is just happily picking away at the soil and by evening, no egg. But she keeps watching, the next day, and the next. But after a week, the chicken has not yet laid an egg, so the teacher comes to her and tells her.

~“Oh, I forgot to mention. The bird, it’s a rooster.” They both had laughed so hard, and that evening, at dinner, they had the most delicious cock-in-wine an elven chef could cook up. That’s the kind of thing you learn at elven school. But while she’s waiting, she hears something, far, far away—elves have very sharp ears, literally and figuratively. Someone is plotting something bad!? It’s the king of the Long Beards, who has been summoned by the evil *χākān* of the Avar.

~“How can you let your people almost starve to death, when those mis-gifted people are living in that rich land? Should you and your long-bearded kin not be the rightful heirs of that blessed land? Pledge your allegiance to me, and I will see to it that the Emperor withdraws his support for Kunimund, and then his land will be for the taking, so that your people can become the truly gifted.” The king of the Long Beards, he seems to mull over the *χākān*’s proposal. Our elven daughter gets worried that he might commit some ill-advised act. With her mental eye—yep, elves also have one

of those—or two, it’s hard to tell—she can now even see his face, and he is holding one of his coins in his hand, looking at it and mumbling:

~“Am I then not the chosen one? My beard is the longest of them all, so therefore should be my rule!” And if she twists her neck a little, our elf can even read the king’s name on the coin. It’s a little hard to see, there is this smudge in the middle, so his name... it reads something like Elvenf•iend. Is that now a good or a bad omen? She doesn’t know. But she’s about to find out that the king of the Long Beards, Elvenf•iend, is going ahead with this evil plan. For, the next day, with a large host, he invades the land of the Gifted, he storms the palace, and kills just Kunimund and his noble consort. Oh dear, oh dear! And poor Rose-o-World, he drags her with him. The older elf shoves our elven daughter forward, indicating with his head that she should follow. And so she does, to the tent of king Elvenf•iend. And she overhears him tell poor Rose-o-World what her new fate will be. ~“Your kin are no longer, Rose-o-World. Now you belong to me. My poor wife has been killed by one of your people’s hunting parties, and thus I have avenged her death. And now you shall take her place, and you shall take care of...,” from behind a curtain, he pulls a little girl, “my beloved daughter, Alba.” And that’s when the elf knows who her new ward will be: the little princess of the Long Beards, the shining Alba, white as the dawn, fair as the night.

And so, Rose-o-World becomes Alba’s second mother. And in spite of the evil deeds of her new husband against her kin, she takes the child in her custody, and raises her as her own. But then, that wicked *χākān*, he breaks his promise. For the Avar, they are renown to be the most untrustworthy and insatiable nation.¹ And so, the *χākān* now tells Elvenf•iend that he is not allowed to take that fertile land. It is to be for his own men. And instead, he tells king Elvenf•iend to go look elsewhere for some rich land. The elf now feels sorry for Alba’s father, a king misled—so, not all kings are that smart?

¹Theofilaktos Simokattis, I.3.2.

But our elf, she has heard of a good and rich land, and so she whispers in Alba's ear when she sleeps—see that's how the elves help us, by whispering good advice in our ears when we sleep—she whispers

~“Italia.” And the next day, little Alba tells her father

~“Daddy, let's go to Italy, you and mom Rose-o-World, and all our people.”

~“What a splendid idea, daughter. I will tell my men right away. They will be so excited. When I went there as a young man to fight for the Emperor, I saw with my own eyes their rich cathedrals and their luxurious villas. Our people will love it there.” And so, the people of the Long Beards, they all go to Italia. But the Emperor is not too pleased, and he sends an army to stop them. And there is a lot of fighting—and when there is war, the farmer can not till the land, and the cobbler cannot repair the shoes, and... The elf thinks to herself.

~“Was that wise of me, to tell them to come here? For there is but famine and hardship, and disease of smallpox greatly afflicting Italy, with cattle perishing in all places.² *Āy wāy*, what have I done?” And so the Long Beards pull their beards in anger, reproaching king Elvenfiend for bringing them to this cursed land. ☹️

—“See, children, it is not easy to be a ruler of men, for men do not always like to be ruled.”

—“Why, Varaz? If the king takes care of them and protects them, then they should not complain.”

Yep. That's exactly what this story is about: youth's naivete.

—“You're right, Borān. But people can be stubborn. And so can be kings.”

And king Elvenfiend now grows warier with the day.

~“Why do they not accept me as their benevolent king?!” And to drown his unhappiness, he starts to drink more wine than he should.

~“My liege, you should not drink that much,” poor Rose-o-World warns her husband, while holding little Alba between her legs, “you're scaring your daughter with your an-

²Marius of Avenches, 571.

gry rants."

~"Scared! You should all be! For I am king. Look how long my beard is. No one has a beard that long, and so no one should impugn me." And he is so angry, that he goes to a cupboard and pulls out another drinking vessel.

~"And instead of challenging me, woman, you shall join me in my inebriation. Drink!" But the cup, children, is not a normal cup! ♣

—"What, Varaz, what is it?"

—"Oh, this is quite gruesome. Perhaps I should not tell."

—"Oh, no, Varaz, you have to tell. We need to know what happens to Alba and her elven friend."

Reality often more gruesome than fantasy is. For, to her horror, Rose-o-World recognizes the cup: it is made from the skull of her departed father. That vile *χākān* had Kunnimund's dead body desecrated, to fashion the unfathomable, to flaunt the ferocity of his kin, to turn the dome of percipience into a vessel of crapulence. And to confound evil with spite, he had sent this morbid device to king Elvenfiend with a letter saying

~"As a parting gift, I give you the last misgiving of the Gifted!" And now, in his drunken stupor, the king has lost all his senses, and he forces his new bride to drink from that horrible cup.

~"Join me, Rose-o-World, and drink merrily with your departed father.³" She has no choice but to go through with this calvarian calvary! The elf thinks to herself

~"Are kings not to show restraint and modesty? Apparently, wine washes all that away."

But later that night, with her sharp ears, she overhears another plot. This time it is Rose-o-World and she is conniving with the king's brother.

~"Helmilyis, you always pledged your love to me. But I am a good Christian princess, and so, I never reciprocated your feelings out of piety. However, this evening, my husband has crossed a line by making me drink from the skull of my

³Paul the Deacon, II.28.

beloved father, just Kunimund. By committing this atrocity, I hate him even more and I now await the opportunity to avenge the wrong done to my dear father.⁴ It is you, I love, Helmilyis, and to whom I pledge my heart. But we can only be together, if you avenge my honor and slaughter that pig in his bed. And together we shall rule the Long Beards!”

Having heard this sinister plot, our elf is torn. Should she save Alba’s father from this murderous plot, or should she let Alba’s new mother—for she loves her stepdaughter dearly—be free from the barbarian shackles of the Long Beards’ king? This kind of stuff, she has not learned in elven school. That right and wrong are sometimes left or twisted?! What is she to do? And she thinks, perhaps, when in doubt, do nothing?

And so, she waits for events to unfold. For a bitter dagger to find its way between Elvenfriend’s ribs. For salty tears to flow from poor Alba’s eyes for the loss of yet another parent. For Helmilyis to pledge his sweet love everlasting to Rose-o-World, becoming her new husband, Alba’s new father. For the new royal couple about to take their seat on their thrones, only for the long-bearded nobles to cry out sourly, to hapless Rose-o-World and her lover:

~“Be gone, you ungrateful witch, and take that conniving brood, your debauched lover with you. He will not be our king. No one will. We are better off without one!” And so, Rose-o-World and her lover have to flee in the night with little Alba, to the Roman governor in Ravenna. And the governor is very happy to welcome them, for since ever, he has had an eye on his rivals’ beautiful wife. He thinks

~“Rose-o-World, what’s in a name? That which we call a rose in any other world, still she would smell as sweet.”⁵ And with every single day, he lusts more after his new guest. And one evening, our sharp-eared elf hears him command his servant to bring a poisonous cup to Helmilyis’s quarters. So, our elf, she quickly whispers in Alba’s ears

⁴Gregory of Tours, IV.41.

⁵Shakespeare, *Romeo and Juliet*, II.2 (paraphrased).

~“...go warn your uncle!” But when little Alba runs with her maidservant to her stepfather’s room, ..., oh no children. Not only is she too late to save poor Helmilyis, but... ❧

—“What Varaz? What is happening?”

W^Hat madness has befallen kings! For poor Rose-o-World, unaware of the poison in the wine, she offers the cup to her husband. But then, when Helmilyis feels that he has drunk the cup of death, he compells Rose-o-World.⁶

~“I should have listened to the Long Beards: unforgiving is your kin, gifted only in treacherous witchcraft. Oh, don’t think that I haven’t seen how that lecherous governor looks at you. But I shall be the last Long Beard you bring to ruin,” and he draws his dagger and holds it against her throat, while putting the poisoned cup in her hand, “drink, so that your punishment will fit your crime.” And poor Rose-o-World, she cannot ward off this enological enormity of cosmic karma, being punished for the crime she did not commit. So, to her horror, Alba, together with her guardian elf, has to watch her new parents leaving her behind once more. But in her last motherly act, Rose-o-World whispers in the maidservant’s ear

~“Alba might not be my blood, but she is my life’s breath. And as that is about to leave me, so have you to leave for Konstantinoupolis with her. I secretly have readied passage for you both on a ship to the capital. Go seek help with the Emperor!”

The elf is grateful for queenly foresight—at least some things she learned in school hold true, like the wisdom of queens—, and so, with the maidservant, in the dark of the night, they board the ship to their new destiny. Our elven daughter, she is quite excited. She’s going to meet the Emperor and the Empress! But then, those sharp ears of her. She picks up something else, even more foreboding, even more ominous... ❧

—“What, Varaz?”

⁶Paul the Deacon, II.29.

She really starts to feel sorry for this little princess: twice she lost her parents, and she always has to be on the run. It's a bit like what happened to mommy Mariam, but way worse.

IN the imperial chamber, she overhears a sinister conversation. It's the Empress, and she tells her husband, the Emperor,

~"How unjust of those Persians, to remove from your mind sober and considerate thoughts, making you fall into this state of frenzy.⁷ But do not despair. With a gifted girl, I can turn the curse. And I just got word from one of our governors, that there is one on her way to us. From the wench's blood, I will brew a potion that will take away the Persian shroud. And her bones, I will grind into a powder that brings eternal youth. So, your allegiance, husband, will all be mine, and so will your sovereignty, har, har, har, so that unbridled wisdom will rule just in your name, and even more riches will flow into my coffers."

The elf cannot believe what she's hearing: the emperor is mad, and his queen even madder. When did imperial benignity turn into basilosaurian impiety? And it is clear, who the queen's innocent victim is supposed to be: her own ward, little Alba. She has to act quickly. But will whispering in the ear of a six-year old avert this calamity? She has not been so successful in her previous attempts, so, our elf, decides ~"I shall protect by proxy!" And when the maidservant sleeps, she slips into her cabin, and whispers in her ear that when they arrive at the harbor of Unjust Wisdom—children, I have been told that's what the port of Konstantinoupolis is called, although, I might have misheard that. Anyway. When they get there, the elf whispers, they should slip out the back, and seek help of the Queen with the Red Hair. ♣

Hey, that could be her. Or mommy? She looks at auntie, who also seems to know who Varaz is talking about. Interesting!

—"Is she able to save the princess, Varaz?"

⁷Evagrios Σχολastikos, V.11.

Praised be the maid's loyalty, for she succeeds in hiding poor Alba from the Empress's clutches. With the help of the Queen with the Red Hair, Alba is taken to an orphanage, where she grows up, shielded forever from imperial inquiry. And as the years pass, little Alba grows up with all her girl friends, and they have a lot of fun, and our elf can breathe a sigh of relieve. She has done it, her ward is safe again! Can she finally take a little break? A little nap perhaps? And so, she goes lie down in the arms of Morpheus. ♡

—"Who, Varaz?"

—"Oh, that's just an expression to say that you go to sleep."

BUT elves have their own protector who comes to them in their sleep. And so, our little elf dreams of a bright light coming to her—it's so bright, she can't see what it actually is—perhaps, it's just that, light? But then a soothing voice tells her

~"Daughter of the forest, tomorrow you must follow the white bird," our elf has no idea what that means, but luckily, the apparition explains, "the Arian princess, you must follow her to the church of the Saint of Much Desire." And as sudden as it came, the light is gone. What does it mean? Her least favorite subject at school was religion, but now she regrets that she didn't pay more attention, for she remembers hearing about the Arians who are *Tarsāg* [Christian] but the other *Tarsāg* [Christian] say they have it wrong, and so, they persecute them. And her ward Alba, is she not of the Arian creed? But that saint, she has no idea who that is. Saints, though, are they not supposed to be dead? Not much she can do there. So, ready to do what her angelic guardian has told her, just when our elf is about to wake up, there it is again, the bright light, and it says

~"Hmm, you elves can be a little bit slow. So, just to clarify, despite of how it sounds, the white bird, the Arian princess, it's *not* your ward Alba." And with that, our young baffled elf wakes up, none the wiser what to do. Luckily, with her sharp ears, she hears the abbess tell two of the orphans that they will go with her today to the church of the Saint of Much

Desire. And wouldn't you know it, one of the orphans, her hair is white as snow, and she's cute like a bird. And probably, she is also Arian and who is not to say she is also a princess in hiding. Our elf thinks

~"Close enough—let me show that all-knowing Bright Light that I am not dumb! I will follow the white princess-in-disguise to the church of the saint." But when she hears the abbess tell the girls that they will go to church via the valley of the wolves... , well, elves and wolves that barely rhymes, and our elf thinks, I can find my own way, avoiding that lycanthropic trap, using my Grand Place Seeker. But while very reliable close at home, that elvish location device—they just call it GPS—doesn't work that well in this busy city. And so, when she walks down the Mese—that's what they call the main street in Konstantinoupolis—past the vendors and the merchants—wow, she has never seen so much merchandise for sale! All kinds of stuff you can buy here, even things that shouldn't be for sale. She shakes her head, and when she reaches the Forum of Brotherly Love, she sees a sign, Mese, pointing to the left, and so she follows it. And she walks and walks until she reaches the Golden Gate. Wait, that cannot be right! It will take her out of the city, and the abbess clearly said that the church was in the middle of the city. Oh, no, that capricious contraption has directed her wrong, so she runs quickly—luckily, elves can be very quick—back to the forum, and wouldn't you believe it, there is a second sign, also saying Mese, and it points right. Why would you have two streets named the same?! Those *Hromā-yig* [Roman]! No wonder that her GPS was not working properly! So, she hurries, just in time to hear, as she arrives at the church, the abbess telling the white princess that she no longer has to go back to the orphanage but will stay here, where she will be well-cared for. The elf thinks

~"Yay! Another mission brought to its proper conclusion." But when she wants to see where the white prince is going, something distracts her. The abbess is talking to someone claiming to be the owner of the church. Now, even from afar, our elf could tell that this was a magnificent church, with an

enormous dome the likes no one had ever seen before. So, now she is curious—one of the elven vices—, who then is the owner of this marvelous building?

~“Welcome, Reverend Mother, to my church. I am . . .” ☘

He pauses, for he knows what inevitably will happen when he utters the name.

—“...Iouliaana Anikia.”

—“Iouliaana Anikia!? Varaz, she is my illustrious ancestor!”

The inevitable reaction of the youngster: Shirowe can never pass up the opportunity to mention his elevated pedigree.

—“Oh, yes, Varaz,” how cool is that, her own family appearing in the story—perhaps there are going to be more, “Grandmama Iouliaana made this beautiful book, full with birds and plants. Remember, Āzar?”

—“Oh, yeah, Varaz, it’s so pretty!”

He has heard of this famous illustrated medicinal book—he had no clue that there were also birds in it.⁸ But the even more surprising fact was that the children had actually seen the book. How was that possible?

—“When did you guys see it?”

—“At Lady Kāren’s. Mommy says she uses the book to heal people in her hospital. Next time we go to Gondeshāpur, you have to come with us, Varaz, and we will show it to you.”

He looks baffled at the *Bāmbishn*, who luckily explains.

—“Lady Mataswintha, their great grandmother, had commissioned for Doctor Kāren, an illuminated copy of princess Anikia’s manuscript, itself a copy of Dioskourides’s pharmacopeia.”

Wow, that explains that.

BUT not a book, but a whole church, Lady Anikia has built. And so, our curious elf follows the abbess and that other orphan into the church. She has to blink a few times, for the light of the sun bounces off all the golden plates on the ceiling, and the geometric patterns interspersed with curiously looking peacocks, all in a dizzying array of light and shadow. Wow, our elf, thinks, this is so pretty. Even for eleven standards.

⁸Vienna Dioscorides, folio 483v.

*What richly wrought and gracious splendor
of which a great epoch cannot celebrate.*⁹

And Iouliana explains.

~“All this is from Persia. Where art and architecture have combined into artifaction. See, when my husband went to Persian lands, I accompanied him, to learn of their marvels. And voila, I made it even better than Solomon, King of the Jews, did. But now that jealous, conniving emperor wants to outdo me and build a dome even higher than mine. But that’s not why I called you here, Reverend Mother, for I have a matter of great import to discuss with you, and frankly, it mystifies me.”

~“Dear Lady Anikia, it will be my honor to help you with this conundrum. What is it?”

~“Have you heard of queen Holycrux?” 🍷

—“Do you guys remember her, queen Holycrux?”

—“Oh, yes, Varaz, she is the one who made the holy Wood of Truth with a big cross.”

Rather the holy monastery of the True Cross, but close enough.

—“Indeed.”

THE abbess confirms

~“She was my savior when I was a lost soul in the land of the Illustrious Quarrelers. She was my mentor, when I was a bride in search of her celestial Bridegroom.” The elf remembers reading somewhere that for a *Tarsāg* [Christian], the highest virtue for a devout girl is to become the Bride of ΧΡΙΣΤΟΣ, forswearing all mortal men.

~“What a fortuitous coincidence,” Iouliana is excited, “I shall therefore, without any hesitation, entrust you with my secret. See, queen Holycrux, she wrote to me a long time ago. But you know, the postal services, they can be slow, and the letter must have gone lost, so I just got it last week. It is written, however, in *Theodisk* [Dutch]—to thwart the prying of imperial eyes. It is your mother tongue, right, Reverend

⁹Epigram 1.10.49–50.

Mother?"

~"Indeed. I shall be happy to assist. Please show me the letter."

~"Now, in all honesty, you're not the first of your kin wanting to read the letter."

~"Oh, no?"

~"A prince of your royal house came by the other day. And he claimed that he was to collect what his sister-in-law had requested: the skull of the Saint of Much Desire," the elf thinks to herself that they'd better not make a drinking cup out of this one, "but in my old age, I have grown suspicious of royalty. They connive and condone, they meddle and malign. . . . Look, up there, all that gold covering the ceiling. It used to be my precious jewelry, heirlooms from my ancestors. But the Emperor coveted it, and the only way I could protect it from his avarice was by having it molten into these golden plaques. And so, when he came to collect his alleged dues, I pointed up and told him, 'My poverty lies up there. Do with it as you please.'¹⁰ Ooh, he didn't like that, ha, ha."

~"Even an Emperor cannot profane hallowed halls." They all look up, Iouliana, the abbess, and our elf. And also that other orphan.

~"It actually turned out rather nice, no?"

~"Indeed, worldly grant in praise of Lordly Grace."

~"Ha, ha, I never thought of that. That makes me indeed feel better. But so, coming back to this prince who claimed to be Queen Holycrux's emissary. . . , it didn't sound right."

~"Who did he say he was, that prince?"

~"His name was Gundowald."

~"Him!? Well, your suspicion is not unwarranted: prince Gundowald is the king's bastard son, and when he lost all royal claims, he defected to the Romans. I doubt noble Holycrux would want to align herself with such a shady character." But when the abbess translates the letter, she discovers even more princely deception. The relics are not intended for Queen Holycrux, but for her cousin, Queen Brunnahilt.

¹⁰Gregory of Tours, *Glory of the Martyrs*, 102.

And she promises Iouliana that with the help of the Queen with the Red Hair, they will get the relic safely to its rightful owner. ♫

—“You’re making it all up, Varaz!”

Apart from the fact that Iouliana Anikia had already passed, and instead there had been just a deacon of the church, all of it actually happened. He got it first-hand from his eyewitness. But as a scrupulous storyteller, he’s not going to reveal his source, and so, in this tale, she will remain ‘that other orphan’.

—“I tell it as it has been told to me by the spirits of the Orb, Shirowe. But, children, the elfquest is not yet finished.”

Our elf is happy. Another task brought to its correct completion. Although, . . . the women’s qualms about royalty. . . at first, she thought it was misplaced resentment, but in the end, it sounded that they were actually right. Late at night, when every one is back to sleep, while watching over sleeping Alba, our elf ponders.

~“What wretched tale fate has thrown me in, where kings are not always that just, and queens not always that noble. Hopefully, that will be the end of this frenzied fray I have been fretted with.”

But not a week later, another alarming conversation she overhears. It is the abbess and she is talking to . . . prince Gundowald! Has the abbess betrayed Lady Iouliana? She hurries to the room, and she hears the abbess reassure the prince that

~“... the girl is not here.” It takes a little while for the elf to figure out that the abbess is talking about her ward, Alba. It turns out that Alba’s birth mother was a sister of this Gundowald. What bad fortune is coming to poor Alba this time? For prince Gundowald insists

~“Reverend Mother, perhaps someone has duped you in believing there is no such girl here, but she is my niece and I will find her and take her with me, sweet Alba, to our land of Illustrious Quarrelers. My niece will be the dower that has been denied to me! Assemble all the orphans in the great hall and I will find her.” Oh, no, that shady prince has now come

for her ward! She has to do something. Our elven daughter looks around. The abbess and the prince have already left. It's just that other orphan, the one from the other day. Quick, she has to tell her to hide Alba. But the girl is awake! Luckily, she looks a little half-witted, being all smudged and dirty—see, when humans are half asleep, an elf can very carefully skulk close to whisper in their ears. Only a single word, though. It does make that other orphan upset.

~“*Ballanbilaigonds, dungonitands*, what is that buzzing in my ears? Hey, stupid fly! Get away,” she swats in all directions, “why are you sounding like *bbbzztunnelzzz*. . . . Hey, that almost sounds like. . . tunnels? Oh, I remember, there is one right here in this room. I would have never thought of that had it not been for that fly. But that's how I can bring my friend Alba to safety!” And that other orphan now runs to get Alba away from the prying eyes of her uncle Gundowald, through the tunnel, to the ruins of an old temple. And there, shrouded by the darkness of the night, in DEMETER's embrace, our elf stays with scared Alba, while that other orphan runs back to the orphanage. And the prince of the Illustrious Quarrelers searches the place up and down but cannot find his niece. And thus his wicked plot to use his niece as ransom for regaining his throne is foiled. And to celebrate their victory over imperial meddling, the abbess orders a big feast for the orphans and they all eat delicious *kakaviá*. 🍷

—“What is *kakaviá*, Varaz?”

Oh, she remembers. Mommy Mariam once told her, and then aunt Peristerá made it for them.

—“Oh, Abrangih, its like a soup with fish in it, and mommy says if you put enough saffron in it, then it is the most delicious dish the *Hromāyig* [Roman] ever came up with.”

—“Indeed. Does this then mean that the elf's troubled times finally have passed?”

Life at the orphanage is continuing again in its usual fashion. All seems peace and quiet, so, once more, our elven daughter decides to take another little nap. Even an elf needs

a little respite once in a while. But she fell so deep asleep that she didn't hear the commotion in the streets. She is missing all the action, where one emperor tries to oust the other. And it is mayhem all over the place. A lot is happening, but our elf, she is so sound asleep! And when she finally wakes up, another alarming conversation she overhears in the abbess's chamber.

~"Tell the Empress that princess Alba was sent to Persia! More, I do not know. The empress should consult the Queen with the Red Hair, who made the arrangement!" Oh, no, our elf slept through her ward's transfer! She jumps up and runs as fast she can to Persia. But, she doesn't trust her GPS anymore, so how to find Persia, . . . , oh, no problem! There is an old elven saying that all roads lead to Persia, so, she thinks, it doesn't matter what road I take, I will get there and then I can make sure that the Persians treat my ward properly.

Now, if this would have happened a few years back, when our elven daughter had not seen the vicissitudes of the world yet, she would not have worried too much. For in elven school they all learn that the Persians always think good thoughts, utter good words, and perform good deeds. But they said the same about kings and queens, and that turned out not to be true: all monarchs she encountered so far were of dubious morals—perhaps with the exception of the Queen with the Red Hair. But one out of many, not very confidence-instilling, so, our daughter of the forest now wonders:

~"How much can I trust the Persians to stick to their ethics? No, I have to make sure that nothing untoward happens unto my ward." So, out of breath, she arrives just in time at the palace of the *Shāhān-Shāh*, only to see him . . . 🍄

—"The *Shāhān-Shāh* is not going to do something bad to Alba, Varaz!"

—"Well, we will never know, for . . ."

TO the elf's astonishment, it is not Alba whom the *Shāhān-Shāh* cordially invites into the palace, but . . . that other orphan. And the elf realizes that it was all a ruse of the abbess, to get the empress's dogs of the princess's scent. Her ward is still safely hidden away at the orphanage—she does

get a little mad with herself for not first checking. Now, she has come all this way! She looks around. Wow, it's true what they say,

*Until at the Persian court you have been
not even half the world you have seen.*

So, she thinks to herself, why don't I stick around a little longer, to go look at all the beautiful halls in the palace. ♣

—"Children, our elven friend," he pretends to look around, "perhaps she is even in this very room? Marveling at the gorgeous carpets and the silken cushions."

Now they all start looking around. Could it be? Until her brother has to spoil it again...

—"Nitwits, elves do not exist! Varaz is making it all up."

—"Well, Shirowe, there are others who have put their faith in our elf. Listen..."

Running all this way from Konstantinoupolis to Tisfon, that has made our elf a bit tired, so, she thinks, perhaps another quick nap? But elves are not the only ones visiting dreams. Once more, a bright light appears in her sleep and it is calling for her.

~"Ele! Awaken, elf. The hour of Cuivienyarna is near," the bright light flickers a little, "well, I said that wrong. Obviously, I don't want you to wake up otherwise, what am I doing in your dream." And then another bright light appears beside the first and our elf hears

~"Oh, sister, you're such a klutz! Let me handle this. The young prince you're supposed to take care of, well, he fell asleep, so go visit him, as you're supposed to!" The other light grumbles.

~"Alright, I'll go. But each time I have to revert to my former avatar. Not fun, you know!" And with these words, the first bright light flies away—wooh, that was so bright!—the second one, luckily, that's just a greenish glow in the darkness of the room. So now, our elf can better see who it is.

~"Oh, wow, you're a *Senmurw* [Simurg]!"

~“Didn’t they teach you in elven school that we, *Senmurw*, are you wards? Well, I guess not. From what I can tell, they have taught you just a load of bosh. It’s time, elfin kin, you learn how the world turns.”

~“It turns?”

~“Well, yeah, but that’s not the kind of heliocentrism I want to impart on you, at this late hour.”

~“It’s late?”

~“You’re reaching your eleventh hour, my dear. But even who is hired at this elven hour will reap its due.¹¹”

~“Like money? I don’t...”

~“Of course, not silly elf, will you stop already with the questions and let me explain,” the glorious bird pauses, as if pondering what to say next, “You know what, I’d better show it to you. Come on, hop on my back. Here, have a fig. It helps with air sickness.”

~“Air sickness?” The *Senmurw* shakes her head: those youngsters, always with their questions. And so, the *Senmurw* and her ward fly high in the sky to... ✨

—“Where are they going, Varaz?”

—“I said that wrong...”

They fly in the sky *through* space and time, until they arrive, far in the east, at a little rivulet where there stands a single tower.

~“This, my elfin pupil, is the border between Erān and Turān, agreed upon by the rulers of both sides. But some kings, they want more than what they have been allotted. Look, there, leading his host, an army of ten-thousand soldiers, marching towards the lands of their enemy, there is the Victorious King of Erān, set on taken the land beyond the tower. His nobles have pleaded with him to not go forward with his imprudent plan, but he has dismissed them. Listen how noblesse and sagesse makes way for superciliousness and recklessness:”

~“You call yourselves paladins! But what do you know of true statesmanship? You are just content to rule your petty

¹¹Matthew, 20:9 (paraphrased).

kingdom, but I shall rule the world!"

~"But sire, it is a primordial sin to break a sworn oath. We swore upon MEHR and SROSH and RASHN, that that tower there shall define the border between our two lands, and none shall cross it to the other side without permission!"

~"Pff, infidels! Has not OHRMAZD Himself endowed Us with His *farr* [divine glory], so that We shall rid the world of these Turanian demons, who do not know right from left, front from back, and all other kind of perversities, for which We deem it not permissible to leave the land in their hands.¹² And thus, disbelievers, when We will appear before Our Judgment at the day of Our Reckoning," he means when he is dead, "We will cross that bridge when We come to it, for MEHR will judge Us well for the good deeds We have performed."

~"O Lord, is it not written that MEHR reaches out with his long arms, to catch the *mehrdroz* [oath breaker] even at the eastern river, and He will smite him down?¹³ By Your sacrilegious acts, You will bring drought and famine upon Erān."

~"You quote some obsolete scripture to Us, but can you not see that with this ingenious plan We so articulately conveyed to you, We will carry out the most glorious deed: ridding the world of the Turanian demons." The elf is curious, so she whispers to the *Senmurw*.

~"Is it true that the Turanians are demons?"

~"No, of course not, they are just people like anyone else. The true demons are hubris and greed. But the foolish king does not want to hear the good counsel of his nobles. A very dangerous premise!"

~"Yeah, I didn't know that kings could be so obstinate. Just look at what they did to my poor ward, Alba."

~"Indeed. You did good, elf, to protect her."

Our elven friend still feels bad though for all the dead bodies they left behind in their wake. Granted, except for Rose-o-World's poor parents, they were all guilty. It's all so

¹²Tabari, 873.

¹³Mihr Yasht, 104.

confusing! However, something the Persian king said piques her curiosity.

~“Great *Senmurw*, do the Persians not believe this? That whoever has ill thoughts, or speaks unjust words, or commits wicked deeds, he will be judged by their deity at the time of their death, thrown in the abyss of hell?”

~“Yes, MEHR will mete out his punishment in accordance to the deeds committed in order for justice to prevail.” Okay, that’s good, but is it good enough? She can but wonder whether deferred justice is really justice.

~“But what of those who are thought of badly, who are spoken to disrespectfully, who are treated unjustly? They suffer without recourse?”

~“Indeed, like what this foolish king is about to do. It will be the ruin of many, and there are not enough elves in the world to save them all. Listen to his foolish plan.”

The King rises up and exclaims.

~“To assuage your petty worries, tomorrow, when We march, We will order for 50 elephants to be linked together to have the tower dragged forward, while We come along behind it.¹⁴ And thus, We will never have violated Our contract, to not go beyond the tower! And to show you that We have all the faith in Our cunning plan, Our wives and children will march beside Us!” The elf looks at her avian guide.

~“Will that work?”

~“No, of course not. It’s the same trickery as in this story. There was once a scribe who had a beautiful shield. And he wanted it engraved with an image of the Sun, for he prayed everyday to MEHR, Who is the Sun. So, he went to the shield-maker in his village and gave him the shield to fix it. And the shield-maker told him how much it would cost and the scribe agreed and paid the fee. But just to make sure that he got his shield back, they made a contract saying:

... , when I, Delgushnasp the shield-maker, will have completed it with the face of the Sun, I will give it back by

¹⁴Tabari, 878.

*the end of the month, and if I cannot finish it by then, that what I owe shall be doubled.*¹⁵

But when the month had passed, the shield-maker had not yet completed his work. And so, he told the scribe that by the end of next month, he would return to him two shields, as stipulated by the contract. But then that month also passed and he had not yet given back the two shields, so the shield-maker told the scribe that he was sorry, but that the scribe shouldn't worry, for by the end of next month, he was going to give him double the amount of shields, four in total. But that month, he did not give the four shields either, but instead promised to double the amount by next month: eight. And so on and on. And now, two full years have passed and the dishonest shield-maker has yet to give back the shields—God-only-knows-how-many..." ۞

—"16,777,216!"

Of course that not only God would know that number! But how does the *Bāmbishn* calculate these things so fast?

—"Well, children, pushing the boundaries—literally or figuratively—how proper is that?"

THE *Senmurw* stretches herself and says in an angry tone—it is a little scary, when she does that.

~"As if MEHR, the Slayer of oath-breakers, would not see through such foolish deceit. But apparently, it has the *Shāhān-Shāh's* nobles fooled, for they no longer object."

~"Then we have to stop him, noble bird!"

~"You forget that we are still in your dream. Our actions will be futile here. But do not despair. There is one who has taken the task to stop the foolish king."

~"Who?"

~"Look, you see that youngster there, he slipped in the back of the luggage train, and while all the soldiers are resting in their tents, he is stealing their boots."

~"Why?"

¹⁵Tabaristan archive, 15.6–13.

~“To sow confusion. To slow them down. That is all he can do for now, for he is alone, and he cannot stop an entire army. He is just one *ayār*.”

~“An *ayār*?”

~“Who has taken up the cause to fight for Justice and All that is Right, even if his king dismisses it!”

~“A noble sentiment—a bit like what we elves do, right? But I still fail to see what he is going to do with all these boots. Wow, he really took a lot of them, ..., but he only took the left boots? Why is that?”

~“Be patient, young elf, you will soon see.” So, the next morning, when all the men are well-rested, the Victorious King orders them to stand in battle formation.

~“Let us show our enemy the might of Erān, ten-thousand of the greatest warriors you are, and in rows of 100 men wide, you will march one row after the other, 100 rows of them, a myriad squadron to a victory of mythic scale. And the bards, in their songs of Our praise, they will call Us the Tenthousandfold Victorious One.” But the *darigbed* [major-domo] comes running and exclaims

~“Your Majesty, an ignoble thief has come in the night and has stolen some of our men’s boots.” Yeah, a soldier might need his armor and his sword and his dagger, but he definitely cannot walk barefoot onto the battle field. And with just their right boots, they cannot hop along either.

~“Okay, let those men stay behind. They will be our rear-guard. But all in formation, now!” But of course, with the missing men. . .

~“Your Majesty, with those men gone, the back rows are no longer 100 men wide. ”

~“We cannot have that. Order is of prime importance—we are not some bunch of barbarians running haywire. Form a squadron, with fewer men wide then.” And the general tells them to stand in rows of 90 wide—he thinks that must work. And behold, when the last men form the final row, they are exactly 90 of them, to complete the row. Perfect, the *Shāhān-Shāh* thinks. But then. . . there is another soldier coming running towards them.

~“*Abaḡshāyid* [sorry], guys, but I really had to go, behind that tree. But I am back now. So where do I stand?” *Pargast*, with 90 men wide, there is now just one soldier too many. So, the king asks
 ~“By the way, how many men have lost their boots.”
 ~“Ninety-nine, Sire.” ❧

As he suspected, the *Bāmbishn* immediately starts to chuckle. She is amazingly clever like that—it had taken him and his friend Peroz Husrow a whole week to come up with this puzzle.

—“What does that mean, Varaz?”

—“I don’t know either, let’s just watch.”

THE general tries a different combination, but nope, doesn’t work either, and then another one... and another one.... The *Senmurw* snickers
 ~“... prime importance, the king called it, but he forgets the importance of primes, ha, ha. He will never succeed.” The elf doesn’t get it. ❧

—“And if, children, you don’t get it either, your auntie will explain.”

And that way, she’ll be too occupied with explaining to grill him afterwards, ha, ha. For this is potentially the most inflammatory of all of his stories, questioning not only royal prerogative, but also promoting the belief system of the Pahlav—something at least the *mowbed* would not be happy about. But that argument, he still has to make. Treading very carefully.

SO, after many hours of trying, the victorious king gives up. The only solution seems to be putting everyone in a single file, but that is just dumb, for by the time the last one enters Turān, the first one is already in Chin and Māchin.
 ~“Forget about right order! Let’s just go!” But what the *Shāhān-Shāh* didn’t know was that while they were sorting out the exact number of rows they needed for their squadron, some of the Turanians had dug ditches with sharp stakes in, and then had light branches of wood laid over them and covered them with earth.¹⁶ And so, when the *Shāhān-Shāh* steps forward, he tumbles in one of them, and gets impaled, and

¹⁶Tabari, 879.

so the victorious one finds his inglorious end. And all his wives and children are captured by the Turanians. It is a big mess! It makes our elf a little concerned.

~“Splendiferous *Senmurw*, what is going to happen to the young princes and princesses, now that they have been captured? Are the Turanians going to kill them too?”

~“Well, the king’s daughter, she is a very pretty princess, and so *Ṭashnawāz*, the king of *Turān*, thinks:”

~“By the souls of my ancestors, by marrying her, I will both boost my prestige and my passion; I will be the envy of all of *Turān*.”

~“Yeah, kings can be vain like that, elfin girl. And remember, vanity is just one letter away—well, three actually—from insanity.”

~“What will the princess do?”

~“She knows her hallowed task, to preserve at all costs the royal blood. And so she replies:”

~“Lord *Ṭashnawāz*, you are victor and captor of Our honor. Yet, We accept to become Your consort queen, on one condition: that You spare the lives of Our little brother and sister.”

~“Very well, my love. But lest they want to follow in their father’s footsteps, I think I am going to keep them here with me.”

But that is not how things end of course—Persian pride and all that—, for a little later, the Grand Vizier of *Erān* comes with an even larger host.

~“Lord *Ṭashnawāz*, our *Shāhān-Shāh* was foolish to not abide by the sworn pact between our people. He has angered MEHR by showing but contempt for our sacred laws. I plead with you, o Lord, do not make the same mistake by withholding *Erān* its royal heir. We need a king!”

~“But don’t you already have one, the brother of that insolent man calling himself victor ere victory.”

~“Oh, him, the brother? No, he is no good! We want the boy to be our new *Shāhān-Shāh*.”

~“But he is only fourteen years old.”

~“He will have our wise counsel to help him rule, do not worry. And we also request you return his sister, who shall

be his queen. It will be a grand wedding and coronation celebration, all in one. And You are of course welcome to be our guest." ʔashnawāz thinks

~"Hmm, being invited to one of those sumptuous Persian banquets. Those Persians sure know how to party!" And so, he agrees. But then the Vizier adds.

~"Oh, by the way, the pearl that you're wearing in you're earring. It's the Shark Pearl, isn't it? Yeah, we want it back," noticing the disappointed look on the king's face, the Vizier adds, "but you can wear it at the banquet and give it back afterwards." The elf looks puzzled. What shark is the Vizier talking about? So, the *Senmurw* explains.

~"Yet another cautionary tale against the avarice of kings. There once was a shark, of enormous size and dreadful fierceness, who fell in love with a pearl—a gem of wonderful whiteness and greatly prized on account of its extraordinary size.¹⁷ And of course, the Victorious King envied the shark and ordered his fisherman to snatch the pearl away from the shark. But the fisherman pleaded with the *Shāhān-Shāh* to not send him on this perilous quest. To no avail though, and so . . . , well, let's just say, it didn't end well for the poor fisherman. . . ," the bird pauses, "well, now that Erān has a new *Shāhān-Shāh*. . . "

~"Order is restored? Justice will prevail?"

~"Not quite, elfin breed, the circle has yet to be made full again."

~"Huh?"

~"Watch!" The *Senmurw* blinks twice and they jump forward in time and place. They are in the palace now, and the young *Shāhān-Shāh*—he is a few years older, sporting already a little bush on his chin—is sitting on his throne. But he doesn't look too happy. His sister sits next to him and tries to cheer him up, with little success it seems.

~"O sister, that domineering Grand Vizier, he decides everything. And he has taken control of everything: the army, the treasury and even my secretaries do his bidding. I am but a

¹⁷Prokopios, I.iv.19, 14.

puppet in his hands."

~"Dear brother and husband, what will you do?"

~"Remember, sister, that thief who stole all those boots, which made our father lose time with trying to get a marching squadron? He is the cause of our father's demise," he turns to one of his loyal servants, "Go search for this man and when you find him, bring him to me."

~"Dead or alive, Your Majesty?"

~"I want him alive!" And when the agents of the young *Shāhān-Shāh* find the *ayār*, they capture him and drag him before their master. Will this be the end of our brave *ayār*? The elf looks anxiously at her guide—is this how the circle of justice closes?—, but the bird just nods reassuringly.

~"You are the cause of Our father's demise. What do you have to say for yourself?"

~"It was Your father who was the cause of all harm that has befallen Erān, Your Majesty, for he broke a sacred pact. I was but the instrument of MEHR to right this wrong."

~"So, you claim divine sanction."

~"I swore to fight for Justice and all that is Right, by MEHR's grace."

~"So, tell me, knave, killing a king is right?"

~"Preventing a king from committing a grave betrayal is, Your Majesty."

~"What about preventing a king from ruling justly." The *ayār* looks a little puzzled.

~"That would be wrong, Your Majesty. Such a thing I would not let pass!"

~"I am glad to hear you say that. For here We are, king but in name. The Grand Vizier and his house are taking all the riches away from Our lands, the pauper suffers under his oppressive regime, and We can only be helpless onlookers, for We have no army to command."

~"By MEHR, what injustice has been done to You. Let me be Your army, Your Majesty."

~"A single man? I don't think stealing the Grand Vizier's boots is gonna work—besides he is so rich that he probably has ten-thousand boots of the finest leather. So, good luck

with that.”

~“I am not just a man, Your Majesty, I am a cause. And others will join me, they will be my brothers and sisters in arms against the unjust usurpation of wealth by those greedy nobility. They violated the contract that holds together our society: that the farmer shall till the land of which the tax collector will take the king’s fair share, and the craftsman shall make his ware which the merchant will buy at fair value, and in recompense, the king will protect his flock from their foes and will mete out justice, with the aid of his nobles. And whoever breaks this sacred circle, whoever taxes the farmer’s patience, whichever nobleman busies himself with the earning of money, in neglect of garnering fair fame,¹⁸ whichever *Shāhān-Shāh* puts in jeopardy the welfare of his flock, him we will smite in the name of MEHR.”

~“Excellent. Then go topple that overbearing Grand Vizier for Us. Well, and also. For Justice!”

And that’s how our elf witnesses that justice works both ways. For the *ayār* rise against the avid nobles and free the young *Shāhān-Shāh* from his shackles, so that he can rule the land fairly and justly.

Our elven friend is quite impressed.

~“Wow, that *ayār*, he is doing for the world what I am just doing for my charge. I would very much want to be like him, Great Bird. To be one of his sister-in-arms in the service of justice,” and to herself she thinks, “hmm, and also quite a handsome fellow that *ayār* is. Perhaps, I wouldn’t mind being a little more than just his sister, hee, hee.”

~“I was hoping you would say that, sylvan daughter. And I wouldn’t be a *Senmurw* if I could not make your wish come true.” Our elf is still a little apprehensive. After all, did she too not swear an elven-oath to protect her ward at all cost.

~“But what about poor Alba?”

~“She is safe now, no empress or prince can touch her anymore. And that other orphan, she’s also doing well. So, no worries there. I hereby relieve you of your charge, for now,

¹⁸Letter of Tansar, 19.

at the eleventh hour, you are ready for the next stage: the hour of the elven princess who fights for Justice and all that is Right."

~"Yay! What would you have me do, o righteous ripsnorting raptor?"

~"It's quite simple actually. Go to sleep and dream of your future self." That confuses the elf a little.

~"But I thought I was already sleeping. Is this not my dream?"

~"When you dream in your dream, you awaken."

~"Huh?"

~"Well, as they say, it ain't no lie that a double negative is a positive," the elf still doesn't get it, "okay, see, when you're dreaming, your not awake, right? So, if you're dreaming in your dream then you're not not awake!"

Our elf is now utterly confused. But who is she to question the wisdom of the great *Senmurw*. And she can really see herself as a princess, wearing like a nice dress, with a little tiara on her head...—and perhaps, lose the pointy ears, before humans make fun of her. Yeah, she is going to dream about all that. And so...

~"*Drōd* [Hello], I am a knight. Are you... a princess?"

~"Not just any princess, noble *ayār*! I am the one who is going to help you fight for Justice and all that is Right."

~"Huzzah! Then I will be the Knight that stands at your side," and the Knight thinks to himself, "Double huzzah, for she is the prettiest princess I have ever seen!"

And that is how the Princess and her Knight find each other, to become the mightiest warrior duo for Justice and all that is Right. By MEHR! 🍀

She knew it! It was all about the Princess and the Knight after all!

—"Yay!"

And now he waits until someone smites his head. For the Christians will think him a pagan, promoting their enemy's deity MEHR. And the *mowbed* will smash his head for exactly the same reason. And his master the *Shāhān-Shāh*, is probably not too pleased for calling his forefather a *mehrdroz* [oath breaker]. Or perhaps the muses, for this cockamamie story he has concocted, ha, ha. In the meantime, awaiting his natural or supernatural

verdict, he is going to slip out avoiding the *Bāmbishn*'s quizzing, now that she is being accosted by little Āzar about the boots.

—“Why 99 boots, auntie?”

—“Because 189 would be too much to carry!” That of course doesn't help. As smart as the *Bāmbishn* is, her explanation often leaves one wanting. According to *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* Gordiyag, that's because she skips ten steps in her head. And so, now, he is going to figure out with his friend Peroz Husrow over a delicious cock-in-wine prepared with some juicy figs, what these ten steps were, ha, ha.